Balancing Civic Engagement and Ecclesial Integrity: Guidelines for Clergy under Canons 222 & 287

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Abstract

The Clergy are deeply involved with civic engagements in the course of exercising their ministry of Order without necessarily having a clue. In virtually all the Dioceses across the nation, the Clergy are among the prominent drivers of community development initiatives that are aimed at improving the quality of lives of Christ's faithful within their jurisdiction. These Clergy however, see these developmental initiatives that include development of skills, self-esteem, self-development as well as societal development as an integral part of the demand that comes with the assumption of the *tria munera* (*munus docendi*, *munus sanctificandi* and *munus regendi*) that comes with their valid ordination, without even remotely contemplating that such acts have the potential of transforming the socio-political dynamics of the nation. This research will demonstrate through the use of exploratory and descriptive methods that there are Canons in the 1983 Code of Canon Law that confer on the Clergy the onerous duties of paying acute attention to the struggles of the faithful in secular society; including struggles for justice and liberation in the socio-political spaces. The research will also highlight the prohibition that the Supreme Legislator places on the Clergy in Canons 222 & 287 to the effect that in carrying out their legitimate pastoral duties in the Church they should be cautious so that they will not be seen as stepping out of the space of civic engagements to the realm of active partisanship in politics.

Keywords: Civic Engagement, Ecclesial Integrity, Clergy, Guidelines, Kafanchan Diocese.

Introduction

The Church is a perfect society. It is perfect not because of its constituents who are in all purpose and intend frail and imperfect. Its perfection is not moral but social. The term "perfect" comes from the Latin "per factus" which is translated to mean "completed" or "finished". When the term is used in relation to the Church it seeks to establish that the Church is a society that "in fact" has all the necessary means to attain its goal. Whereas the goal and purpose of Political States like Nigerian as provided in the Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria 1999 (as amended) are primarily to promote security and welfare of the people, good governance, social justice, national unity, democracy and overall development of the country;[i] the primary goal of the Church on the other hand are *cultus dei* (Divine worship) and *salus animarum* (salvation of souls) in order to bring the faithful to know, love and serve God above all things and in doing so, to save their souls. To achieve these ecclesial goals the Lord Jesus Christ established the Papacy and the Hierarchy to govern and teach the Church through the exercise of the *potestas iurisdictionis*. Christ has also instituted the Sacraments to distribute grace and to give the Church all the necessary means to ensure healthy, ordered, harmonic and independent Church through the exercise of *potestas ordinis*. The Church therefore is an association of men and women who through saint Peter, the Apostles and their Successors is administered *cum sibi imperio*-without depending on any other authority.[ii]

The Church, while exercising its *potestas iurisdictionis,* teaches that as man strives to attain the life hereafter, which is a Christian's undisputable ultimate goal, he ought to do everything possible to avoid sliding into a life of squalor and deprivation. This teaching buttresses the Church's believe that the life that man lives here on earth must necessarily prefigures the joy that awaits every person that serves God in truth and spirit. It is in the light of this understanding and inspired by the elements of Catholic Social Teaching (CST) that the Fathers of the Church in their 1971 World Synod of Bishops proclaimed that: "Action on behalf of justice and participation in the transformation of the world fully appear to us as a constitutive dimension of the preaching of the Gospel or, in other words, of the Church's mission for the redemption of the human race and its liberation from every oppressive situation".[iii] This Church which acknowledges the lordship and sovereign freedom of God in all strata of life, which includes the political and economic orders, confers on its Clergy the faculty to imbue the world with the liberating message of Christ through the exercise of their *munus docendi* - the power to teach (preach). In preaching and teaching about justice, actions which can be conveniently couched within the acts of civic engagements, the Clergy may frequently address issues which have political ramifications. In this regard, they must be mindful that Canons 285 § 287 prohibit them from having an active role in political parties or in the direction of labour unions unless the vindication of the Church's rights, or the promotion of the common good require it in the judgement of the competent ecclesiastical authority.

This paper will explore the delicate balance between mandatory clerical neutrality as legislated by the Supreme Pontiff in the 1983 Code of Canon Law and the Cleric's prophetic mandate which obliges him to forthtell the presence as enshrined in his authority to teach. The paper will argue that although the Clerics are prohibited from active participation in politics, they are however obliged both in their capacity as citizens and Clerics to use every legitimate means that is not noxious to the law – civil and ecclesiastical- to entrench the recognition, promotion and the service of human dignity, social justice and societal development.

The specific juridical questions with which this paper is concerned with are: What is civic engagement? Can the Clergy be involved with civic engagement? Are there legal basis for such engagement in the 1983 Code of Canon Law? Can a Clergy's involvement with civic engagement compromise ecclesial integrity?

The researcher will employ the use of the exploratory and descriptive methods to respond to the questions that the paper seeks to respond to and he will within the context of the provisions of Canons 285 and 287 propose guidelines that will regulate the activities of the members of the Clergy that are involved in civic engagement.

Clarification of Concepts

It was not the intention of this paper to spend time clarifying the major terms being used in the topic under consideration. However, when the researcher engaged a cross section of over one hundred Priests of the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan who were gathered at their annual retreat, in September, 2026, the lack of agreement among the priests interviewed on the understanding of the major terms used in the topic places an epistemic obligation on the researcher to develop a conceptual framework that will place the discussions within a context. It is to be noted too that the lack of agreement among the Kafanchan diocesan priests with regards the meaning of the concepts being used in the topic under review does not in any way suggests that there will be the same results if the researcher had engaged a cross section of Priests from Enugu Diocese, Onitsha Archdiocese, Lagos Archdiocese, Jos Archdiocese or even Calabar Archdiocese. Their responses

will definitely be determined by the depth of their knowledge of civic engagement and the level of their involvement in it. The researcher's inability to interview other Priests from other Dioceses across the nation is a limitation that will be addressed in future researches.

Civic Engagement

According Zhidong Hao et al., "civic engagement is composed of two parts: social services, including such work as education, health, elderly care, and the care of the sick and the disabled; and civic activism, including such activities as protest rallies, demonstrations, and declarations of positions over various social and political issues".[iv] Robert Putnam on the other hand uses the term broadly. In fact, he does not even attempt to define the term. Rather in his definition of civic disengagement, he covers a gamut of activities including "club meetings, visits with friends, committee services, church attendance, philanthropic generosity, card games, and electoral turnout".[v] Nonetheless, it is probably reasonable to define civic engagement as "the ways in which citizens participate in the life of a community in order to improve conditions for others or to help shape the community's future".[vi] Similarly the American Psychological Association broadly defines civic engagement "as individual and collective actions designed to identify and address issues of public concern".[vii] The American Psychological Association further explains that:

> Civic engagement can take many forms, from individual voluntarism to organizational involvement to electoral participation. It can include efforts to directly address an issue, work with others in a community to solve a problem or interact with the institutions of representative democracy. Civic engagement encompasses a range of specific activities such as working in a soup kitchen, serving on a neighbourhood association, writing a letter to an elected official or voting.[viii]

From the foregoing it can be deduced that there is no consensus on the definition of civic engagement. This is symptomatic of the varied responses received from the Priests of the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan who were interviewed. Some of the responses received to the question "what is civic education?" are framed in these phrases: "Observation of the law of the land". "Giving back to the society without expecting a reward". "Holding the Government accountable". "Helping the poor and those on the fringe of the society". The responses received from the priests interviewed reveal a multidimensional understanding of civic engagement, encompassing legal, social, political, and humanitarian dimensions of participation in society. The responses can be interpreted as reflecting different dimensions of civic engagement; namely, respect for the rule of law, voluntary service to society, political accountability, and social solidarity.

Civic engagement is understood from the perceived mind of the researcher as the process through which an individual roll up his sleeve and plunge himself into purposeful activities that improve his life and that of his fellow citizens. This type of engagement is primarily fueled by the strong desire to promote the common good in the society.

Looking at the various definitions that are adduced, one thing is very clear. Civic engagement revolves around the personal and the corporate desire to pursue the common good which is the sum total of social conditions that allow persons to reach their fulfilment more fully and easily. It could be seen too that there are striking similarities between the constitutive categories of civic engagement and the Church's social teaching which is founded upon the Gospel mandate of love of neighbour. Both civic engagement and Catholic Social Teaching ensure that the dignity of the human person is properly recognised and served in political, social and economic structures.[ix]

Ecclesial Integrity

There are two senses in which the English word "Church" is used. The first derives from the Greek adjective *kuriakos* (belonging to the Lord). This is seen as the short form of what originally is *kuriakon doma* or *kuriakos domos* (the Lord's house). This sense reduces the church to the physical building, which the Christians meet for worship. In ordinary English, the first reference is dominant. The second sense sees the Church as *Ekklesia*. The word *Ekklesia* is derived from the Greek verb *Ekkaleo*, meaning, "to summon", "to call out". In this sense the Church becomes, a convocation, a calling together, an assembly. This sense, dominates the New Testament understanding of the church. In this paper the term Church is used in the second sense as Ekklesia. The Fathers of the Second Vatican Council describe the Church as the "People of God" (Lumen Gentium, n. 2). The Church then is not just an ordinary gathering for men (*Ekklesia tou anthropou*). It is a gathering for God (*Ekklesia tou theou*). It is clear therefore from the explanations given that our understanding of the Church is the People of God that is established by the Holy Spirit as the Body of Christ (Eph. 4:12) and the community of Christ's faithful (*Congregatio Fidelio Christi*).

Etymologically speaking, "integrity" is from the Latin adjective "integer" which is translated to mean the quality of being whole, honest, morally upright, and consistent in one's principles and actions.[x] The fusion of the two adjectives ecclesial and integrity therefore forms a compound word that refers to the Church's faithfulness to its identity, teachings, values, and mission, demonstrated through its words, decisions, and actions.

Clergy

Clergy is an omnibus concept that merges together all persons that are validly ordained in the Church and are involved with a special service to the altar. They are "those persons specially ordained for divine services. They are the Bishops, Priests and Deacons (transient and permanent) (emphasis ours)".[xi] It is an ecclesiastical status which distinguishes the ordained ministers from the Laity.

Inquietude in Nigeria's Socio-Political Spaces

The socio - political history of Nigeria since 1960 is comparable to the story of a strong, wealthy, extravagant giant who suddenly became crippled, impoverished and beggarly at the peak of his fame. Karl Maier has succinctly captured this ugly scenario in Nigeria which was taunted as the giant of Africa thus:

> Designed by alien occupiers and abused by army rule for three quarters of its brief life span, the Nigerian state is like a battered and bruised elephant staggering toward an abyss with the ground crumbling under its feet. Should it fall, the impact will shake the rest of West Africa.

Nigeria, like so many countries in Africa, is patently not a developing nation. It is under developing. Its people are far worse off now than they were sixty years ago. The number speaks for themselves:

> Around 141 million Nigerians - roughly 62% of the population- are projected to live below the national poverty line in 2026, according to PricewaterhouseCoopers' Nigeria Economic Outlook. The World Bank's April 2026 Nigeria Development Update puts the 2025 rate at approximately 63%, projecting only a gradual decline to around 59% by 2028 under baseline conditions. Both figures use the national monetary poverty line. The bottom line: despite real macroeconomic reforms, poverty

in Nigeria in 2026 remains at a generational high, and the pace of reduction is far too slow to meaningfully change households' realities in the near term.[xii]

The two basic interconnected national challenges that plunge Nigeria into the abysmal social development stats are widespread poverty and persistent insecurity. Poverty manifests in inadequate income, unemployment, food insecurity, and limited access to education, healthcare, electricity, and clean water. Insecurity includes terrorism, banditry, kidnapping for ransom, communal violence, farmer–herder conflicts, and other forms of criminal violence.

Socio -Political Plaque in the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan[xiii]

The national challenges that that have plunged the nation into the abysmal stats that are being churned out by the National Bureau of Statistics and other similar organization are very much present in the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan. Frustrated by the frequency with which pastoral agents and their parishes are attacked in his Diocese, the Bishop, Most Rev. Julius Yakubu Kundi had tasked a Three-Man Committee, led by his Vicar General, Fr Emmanuel Faweh Kazah, JCD, to conduct a study on the dynamics of kidnapping and the economic burden it places on the Diocese.

The report which is tagged "Kidnapping Dynamics and Economic Burden in the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan (2011-2026)", presents a multidimensional analysis of kidnapping incidents affecting the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan, Kaduna State, Nigeria, between 2011 and 2026. The Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan covers a geographical area of about 14, 860 square kilometres (5,739 square miles) and it stretches across seven Local Government Areas, namely: Jaba, Jema'a, Kaura, Kauru, Lere, Sanga and Zangon Kataf. Drawing on documented cases across six Local Government Areas (LGAs) and numerous Parishes, the report examines the status, age distribution, temporal trends, spatial patterns, economic implications, and the impact of kidnapping on Clergy, Catechists, Seminarians, and Faith Communities. It also assesses the extent to which existing legal frameworks, particularly the Terrorism (Prevention and Prohibition) Act, 2022 (TPPA 2022), address the needs of victims.

The report reveals that a total of 920 persons were kidnapped within the Diocese during the study period. Of these, 718 victims (78.04%) were released alive, 183 (19.89%) were killed, and 19 (2.07%) remained in captivity at the time of documentation. Unfortunately, all survivors reportedly returned with varying degrees of physical injury, illness, or psychological trauma, indicating that survival did not equate to recovery. The evidence demonstrates that kidnapping has become a source of universal harm, producing death, disability, emotional distress, and long-term socio-economic challenges for victims and their families. The crisis has not spared Church personnel. Several Priests, Catechists, and Seminarians have been abducted, while some lost their lives in captivity. Among those kidnapped were Fr. Johnmark Chetnum, Fr. Cleophas Donatus, Fr. Joseph Shekari, Fr. Uke Gabriel, Fr. Andrew Anana, Fr. Sylvester Ukechukwu, Fr. Jeremiah Kahuwai, Fr. Magnus John, Fr. Nathaniel Asuwaye, Fr. Emmanuel Silas, Fr. James Amos Ibrahim, Fr. Benson Luka, Seminarian Na'aman Danlami Ngofen, Catechist Istifanus Katunku, Catechist Napoleon Dauda, Catechist Ezekiel Dauda, Catechist Kefas Adamu, and Catechist Jacob Akut. Some of these Clergies, including Fr. Johnmark Chetnum, Fr. Sylvester Ukechukwu, Seminarian Na'aman Danlami Ngofen, Catechist Istifanus Katunku and Catechist Napoleon Dauda, were killed, highlighting the severe risks faced by Priests and pastoral agents.

Analysis of the age distribution indicates that adults constituted the overwhelming majority of victims, accounting for 818 cases (88.91%), while children represented 102 cases (11.09%). This pattern suggests that kidnapping is largely driven by economic motives, with perpetrators targeting individuals perceived to possess financial value or access to ransom-paying networks. However, the involvement of children highlights the expansion of insecurity into family and community spaces and raises serious concerns about the long-term psychological and developmental consequences for younger generations.

The temporal analysis reveals a dramatic escalation of kidnapping activities over time. While the period from 2011 to 2019 recorded only 98 victims and less than 1% of the total ransom payments, the years 2024 and 2025 alone accounted for approximately 64.8% of all victims and 83.4% of total ransom payments. This sharp increase indicates that kidnapping has evolved from an intermittent security challenge into a highly organized criminal economy. Total ransom payments during the study period amounted to ₦2,704,329,500, excluding non-cash demands such as motorcycles, livestock, solar panels, food items, and other material assets. The concentration of incidents and ransom payments in recent years demonstrates the growing sophistication and profitability of kidnapping networks operating within the region.

Spatial analysis reveals a highly uneven geographical distribution of kidnapping incidents. Kauru Local Government Area emerged as the epicentre of the crisis, accounting for 420 victims (45.65%) and over ₦1.5 billion in ransom payments, representing approximately 55.6% of the total ransom recorded. Within Kauru, St. Philip's Parish, Kwassam, stood out as the most severely affected parish, with 212 victims and nearly ₦974.3 million paid in ransom. Kauru was also the LGA most affected by the abduction of clergy and catechists. Priests kidnapped within the area included Fr. Johnmark Cheitnum and Fr. Cleophas Donatus at Christ the King Parish, Yadin Garu; Fr. Joseph Shekari formerly of St. Monica's Parish, Ikulu-Pari; Fr. Emmanuel Silas formerly of St. Charles Lwanga Parish, Zambina; and Fr. James Amos Ibrahim of St. Gerard's Parish, Kurmin Risga. Catechists kidnapped in Kauru included Napoleon Dauda of St. Philip's Parish, Kwassam; Ezekiel Dauda of St. Paul's Parish, Kauru; and Kefas Adamu of St. Monica's Parish, Ikulu-Pari. The killing of Fr. Johnmark Cheitnum and Catechist Napoleon Dauda underscores the severity of insecurity in this axis.

Jema'a Local Government Area emerged as the second major hotspot, accounting for 169 victims (18.37%) and ₦339,142,000 in ransom payments. St. Francis Xavier Parish, Godogodo, alone accounted for 103 victims. The area was particularly notable for the repeated abduction of Fr. Andrew Anana formerly of St. Francis Xavier Parish, who was kidnapped twice, as well as Fr. Magnus John formerly of St. Joseph Parish, Kwagiri, illustrating the persistent targeting of Clergy operating within high-risk communities.

Zangon Kataf Local Government Area recorded 154 victims (16.74%) and ₦370,680,000 in ransom payments. Unlike Kauru and Jema'a, which exhibited concentrated hotspots, Zangon Kataf experienced a more dispersed pattern of attacks across several parishes. Clergy and Church personnel kidnapped in the area included Fr. Uke Gabriel formerly of St. Thomas Parish, Zaman Dabo; Fr. Benson Luka formerly of St. Matthew's Parish, Anchuna; Seminarian Na'aman Danlami Ngofen formerly of St. Raphael Parish, Fadan Kamantan; and Catechist Istifanus Katunku formerly of St. Catherine Parish, Zuturung Mago. Both Na'aman Danlami Ngofen and Catechist Istifanus Katunku later died, reflecting the lethal consequences of kidnapping in the area.

Lere Local Government Area accounted for 116 victims (12.61%) and ₦276,190,000 in ransom payments. The LGA also witnessed the abduction of Fr. Jeremiah Kahuwai formerly of Holy Trinity Parish, Karku and Fr. Nathaniel Asuwaye currently serving at Holy Trinity Parish, Karku. Their experiences demonstrate that Clergy serving even outside the principal hotspots remain vulnerable to kidnapping and its associated trauma.

Kaura Local Government Area recorded 38 victims (4.13%) and ₦148,080,000 in ransom payments. Although the number of incidents was relatively lower, the impact on Church leadership was profound. Fr. Sylvester Ukechukwu of St. Mary's Parish, Tachira, was kidnapped and subsequently killed, while Catechist Jacob Akut of St. John the Baptist Parish, Chikka, was also abducted. These incidents illustrate that lower-frequency attacks can still result in devastating human losses. Sanga Local Government Area remained the least affected, accounting for 28 victims (3.04%) and ₦76,400,000 in ransom payments. Nevertheless, the broader diocesan experience demonstrates that no part of the Diocese is entirely insulated from the threat of kidnapping.

The report further highlights the devastating economic consequences of kidnapping on faith communities. Between 2020 and 2025, the combined diocesan income from harvests, offertory collections, and tithes amounted to ₦304,143,745. In contrast, ransom payments during the same period totalled ₦2,491,127,038, creating a financial gap of over ₦2.18 billion. This means that ransom payments were approximately 8.19 times greater than the Diocese's total legitimate income. The disparity illustrates how kidnapping has become an informal system of violent taxation, forcing households and communities to liquidate assets, incur debt, deplete savings, and redirect resources away from education, healthcare, agriculture, welfare programmes, and community development.

Beyond its economic consequences, the report demonstrates that kidnapping has generated widespread fear, trauma, social disruption, and community fragmentation. High-risk Parishes face increased pastoral burdens, including trauma counselling, victim rehabilitation, family support, and crisis management. The repeated targeting of Priests, Catechists, and Seminarians has intensified these burdens and created leadership challenges within affected communities. The cumulative effect is the transformation of the Church from a purely spiritual institution into a humanitarian responder dealing with the long-term consequences of violence.

The report also exposes significant gaps in the implementation of Nigeria's Terrorism (Prevention and Prohibition) Act, 2022. While the Act contains provisions relating to victim protection, rehabilitation, restitution, and support through forfeited assets, there is no evidence that victims within the Diocese have received meaningful compensation or structured recovery assistance. Consequently, affected individuals and communities continue to bear the overwhelming financial and psychological costs of kidnapping.

The report concludes that kidnapping in the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan has evolved into a multidimensional humanitarian, security, economic, pastoral, and development crisis. The persistent targeting of Priests, Catechists, Seminarians, and Lay Faithful demonstrates that the crisis extends beyond individual victims to threaten the institutional and spiritual foundations of the Church. Addressing this challenge requires a coordinated response involving enhanced security operations, effective implementation of victim compensation provisions under the TPPA 2022, strengthened community protection mechanisms, psychosocial support services, pastoral care programmes, and targeted economic recovery interventions. Without decisive action, the cycle of

violence, impoverishment, trauma, and social dislocation is likely to persist, further undermining the wellbeing and resilience of affected communities across the Diocese.

The study conducted in the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan, which is a microcosm of the over fifty Catholic Dioceses in Nigeria further demonstrate that Nigeria is facing severe existential trouble marked by deep systemic failures, crushing economic hardships, and a widespread loss of hope among the People of God. The Clergy in the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan as well as Clergy everywhere in the nation do not live behind walls that alienate them from reality. "Irrespective of their political interests and affiliations, it is a fact that the cries of the poor, the displaced, the hungry, and the terrorised pour directly into their Rectories and stare them in the face every day".[xiv]

The Clergy in the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan and in most Dioceses across the nation who daily witness this existential malaise that threatens the life of the faithful are literally fired up with a holy anger to publicly denounce the seeming Government ineptitude to protect the life and property of the Citizens as it is provided in Chapter II of the Constitution of the Federal Republic 1999 (as amended). However, "they are cast in a predicament of two necessities: The duty of proclaiming the Gospel and the obligation of maintaining canonical order".[xv] It is important to explore at this point if there are other provisions in the 1983 Code of Canon Law besides Canon 285 & 287 that would guide competent ecclesiastical authority regarding the absolute canonical prohibition of Priests involvement in partisan politics.

Legal Basis for Clergy's involvement in Civic Engagement

The national socio-political plaque that cast a gloomy pall on the well-being of the around 141 million Nigerians - roughly 62% of the population that live in a multi- dimensional poverty which expresses itself in different shades, sizes and the hues and cries of those that live on the fringe of the society that keeps the Clergy always awake further buttress the fact that "liberation from structures of injustice is increasingly seen as both the pre-condition of evangelization and its effective consequence".[xvi] The position of Pope Benedict XVI is not different from that of the Fathers of the 1971 World Synod of Bishops. The Holy Father wrote: the Church cannot and must not replicate the State in the political battle for a just society, yet she cannot remain on the sidelines in the fight for justice.[xvii] It is a truism that the Church's position, at least from her Social Teachings that whenever human dignity is not properly recognized and served in political, social and economic structures and relations, issues of social justice arise. The Paper will explore the 1983 Code of Canon Law for Canons that empower the Clergy to prophetically address structural injustice in their respective places of apostolate; an action that is akin to civic engagement.

Social Justice and Charity – Can. 222 § 2: Text, Context and Legislative History

Canon 222 is structurally situated in "Book II: *De Populo Dei*- People of God" of the CIC 1983. It is the penultimate Canon of Part I of Book II, titled "*De Christifidelibus* – Christ's Faithful". This part of the Book sets forth the obligations and rights of all Christian Faithful. Therefore, the obligations imposed by this Canon apply to all Clergy and Laity.

Christifideles Obligatione Tenentur Necessitatibus Subveniendi Ecclesiae

The first paragraph of this canon (Can 222 § 1) obliges the Christian Faithful to contribute to the Church in order that the Church may have what it needs for divine worship, apostolic works, works of charity and the support of its ministers. The obligation imposed on the Faithful by the Church in the first paragraph of Canon 222 is a clear demonstration of organizational involvement

in activities that will potentially improve the lot of the people in the social and ecclesial Communities. Therefore, when the Clergy appeal to the Faithful to contribute for the provision of the need of the Church, they are technically involved in civic engagement. The provisions of this paragraph is the juridical rendition of the position of the Father's of the Second Vatican Council when they taught that the Church, despite not having a purpose of a political, social and economic nature, does need human resources to achieve its mission[xviii] which include the worthy celebration of divine worship, the honest sustenance of its ministers and for other ends inherent to it: primarily works of apostolate and charity.[xix]

Obligatione Tenentur Iustitiam Socialem Promovendi

Canon 222 § 2 places the following duty on the Christian Faithful: "They are also obliged to promote social justice and, mindful of the precept of the Lord, to help the poor from their own resources".[xx]

The 1977 Schema on the People of God dealt with the issue of the rights and duties of the Faithful. It contained two Canons which imposed the obligation to foster justice. Canon 20 required all the Faithful to foster unity among all Christians and bound them to the "obligation of promoting peace, founded on justice, among all People".[xxi] Canon 38 of the Schema proposed a similar obligation for all the Faithful:

> All the Christian Faithful, based on the teaching of the Church in social matters, are to promote justice among persons and all peoples, and are to give aid to the works of piety and Christian charity, especially to those by which efficacious help is given to those in need.[xxii]

At a meeting of the *Coetus* on the People of God on October 19, 1979, the Secretary of the Pontificial Commission for the Revision of the Code proposed that Canon 20 should be simplified by removing the "justice" obligation and transferring it to Canon 38.[xxiii] This proposal was approved by all the Members of the *Coetus*. At the meeting of the following day, however, upon considering Canon 38 all Members of the Coetus "agreed that the Canon should be suppressed, because the norm is substantially contained in the *Lex Ecclesiae Fundamentalis* (*LEF*)".[xxiv] Although the *Coetus* indicated no specific Canon in the *LEF*, it was apparently referring to Canon 95 of the *textus emendatus* which provided in its first paragraph that "the Church, in carrying out its role in society, unites itself the members of the society in promoting justice, cooperation, concord and peace among all peoples.[xxv] The second paragraph of canon 95 stated that "the Church participates in the works of society to the extent that they pertain to its spiritual mission, especially by promoting peace in the world in the spirit of the Gospel".[xxvi] However, with the suppression of the provision on social justice in the People of God Schema at the *Coetus'* 1979 meeting and with the eventual decision not to promulgate the *LEF* itself, an explicit reference to social justice was left out of the proposed obligations of the Christian Faithful in the subsequent schemata.[xxvii]

The obligation was reinserted into the final version of the CIC 1983 only during Pope St John Paul II's consideration of the 1982 Schema prior to the Code's promulgation. The duty to promote social justice can therefore be seen as having been given specific endorsement by the Supreme Legislator.

It was James H. Provost who commented that there is no direct source of this Canon in the texts of the Second Vatican Council.[xxviii] However, the Canon's linkage of social justice with assistance to the poor is a clear reflection of conciliar and other magisterial teachings. Indeed, a special solicitude for the poor is a traditional component of the Judeo-Christian sense of justice.

In the Old Testament, Yahweh, shows a special favouritism towards the poor, the weak, the downtrodden, the *anawim*.[xxix] The same concern was manifested in the ministry of the Lord Jesus Christ who challenged the people to be especially responsive to the needs of the poor and the oppressed.[xxx] Provost is right when he noted:

> Without justice there can be no charity; charity provides the completion and ultimate end of justice. Caring for the needs of the poor from one's own resources provides practical attention to the needs of others and an immediate reminder of one's personal responsibilities but should also enkindle a more positive involvement in works of justice.[xxxi]

It is clear therefore as it is affirmed in Canon 222 § 2, Christian social justice is inherently linked to a concern for the poor and the weak, in accordance with "the precept of the Lord". Hence, although social justice may be seen as an obligation of natural law, it is an obligation which acquires a "special importance for the baptized," an obligation of the supernatural order.[xxxii] It is thus a duty of the Faithful, the foundation of which can be seen as "divine natural law or divine positive law," and which has ramifications for the faithful not only in the external forum, in their relations with each, but in the internal forum as well, as regards one's conscience and accountability to God.[xxxiii]

Canon 222 § 2 does not specify how the Faithful are to promote social justice. The manner in which the obligation is to be fulfilled will therefore depend on the abilities of the person, the circumstances of time and place, as well as the needs which exits and the possible ways of responding to those needs. It is to be noted that for the members of the Clergy and the Religious in virtue of Canon 672, have a specific canonical obligation to foster justice (Can. 287§2). This obligation is even higher on the hierarchy as well as those who are in way designated to teach or preach in the name of the Church. They are not only bound by the general obligation of Canon 222 § 2 but are also required to proclaim social justice and challenge the Faithful to work for its establishment (Cann. 747 §2; 768 §2).

Duty of Clergy and Religious – Canon 287 §§ 1-2: Text, Context and Legislative History

Canon 287 § 1 provides that "Clerics are always to do their utmost to foster among people peace and harmony based on justice".[xxxiv] This Canon is located in Part I, Title III: "*De Ministris Sacris seu Clericis- Sacred Ministers or Clerics*", Chapter III: "*De Clericorum Obligationibus et Iuribus*- The Obligations and Rights of Clerics" of Book II of the *CIC* 1983. The provision of this Canon sets forth a duty specific to the Clergy.[xxxv] It should be noted that Canon 672 makes this obligation applicable to Members of the Religious Institutes as well.

Obligatio Pacis Iustitiae Innixae Promovendae

The Clergy have the obligation (duty) to promote peace based on justice. The words "*iustitia innixam- based on justice"* were not contained in the corresponding Canon in the 1977 Schema on the People of God,[xxxvi] but were added to the 1980 Schema (Can. 262 §1) in response to the suggestions of the several Consultors that such an addition be made since peace is to be seen as the product of justice (*opus iustitiae pax*).[xxxvii] This amendment was retained in the 1982 Schema (Can. 291 §1) and was fully incorporated into the *CIC* 1983.

It is no be noted that Canon 287 §1of the CIC 1983 is partly derived from Canon 141 of the *CIC* 1917 which forbade Clerics from participating in any way in civil conflict or public disturbances. It is interesting to note that the 1977 Scheman repeated the CIC 1917's

prohibition.[xxxviii] The prohibition was deleted prior to the publication of the 1980 Schema at the request of the Secretary of the Commission for the Revision of the CIC 1983 who noted that "there are times in the life of a country when Clerics are not able to remain neutral".[xxxix] In 1981 Cardinal Siri sought to have the proscription reinstated. This proposal was rejected, however, since the *Coetus* felt that the prohibition was "understood" already to be included within the meaning of the Canon as it was worded.[xl] Despite this apparent contradiction in the mind of the Commission, a reasonable interpretation of Canon 287 §1 of *CIC* 1983 would harmonize the two positions, such that the promotion of peace would not include Clergy taking part in internal wars or public disturbances unless neutrality were morally impossible in a particular case. A closer study of the Canon will reveal that it generally imposes a "positive" obligation of peace making upon the Clergy.

The words of the Canon "peace …based on justice" were recurrently used by the Popes of the Social Teaching of Church. It would be recalled that Pope John XXIII taught in Pacem in Terris that the dignity of the human person gives rises to certain civil, political and economic rights which must be universally recognized if peace is to be attained.[xli] This wording of Canon 287 §1 also echoes the social teaching of Pope Paul VI in *Populorum Progressio*. There the Pope underscores that peace is not simply the absence of war, but is rather the result of a just order which is pursued and built-up day after day.[xlii] This peace and justice connection was affirmed by John Paul II in *Laborem Exercens*, where he stressed that a commitment to justice must closely linked with commitment to peace in the world.[xliii] The Pontiff specifically affirmed that: "respect for a broad spectrum of human rights constitutes the fundamental condition for peace in the modern world: peace both within individual countries and societies and in international relations…"[xliv] The promotion of such justice entails an involvement in a wide range of civic engagements at the local, national and international stages.

Fulfilment of the Obligation

The CIC 1983 provides the framework for the fulfilment of this duty of the Clergy and Religious to foster peace based on justice. The Church's Social Teaching and its challenge to the managers of socio-political spaces to establish justice in the society must be an integral part of the Gospel that the Clergy and the Religious teach (Can. 747 §2) and preach (Can. 768 §2). The Church's Teaching should be imparted to the entirety of the Faithful through both the traditional means communication and the social media so that they too will rise to the occasion to fulfil their obligation of promoting social justice as it is provided in Canon 222 §2. In this regard, the Clergy have the onerous obligation and responsibility to raise the consciousness of the Faithful regarding issues and works of social justice within their circumscription (Cf. Can. 528 §1).

It is important to clearly state that the tenor of the Canon does not confine the Clergy and the Religious to exercise their *munus docendi* to encouraging and challenging the Christian Faithful alone. They can issue the challenge of justice to the world at large. In this regard they have the right and duty to announce moral principles pertaining to the social order and even, where necessary, the right to make moral judgement on concrete human affairs (Can. 747 §2).

Political Ramification of the Obligation

In teaching and preaching about justice, the Clergy and Religious may frequently address issues which have political ramifications. In this regard, the Clergy are to be mindful of the provisions of Canon 287 §2 which prohibits them from having an active role in political parties or

in the direction of labour unions "*nisi iudicio competentis auctoritatis ecclesiasticae, Ecclesiae iura tuenda aut bonum commune promovendum id requirant* - unless the vindication of the Church's rights or the promotion of the common good requires it in the judgement of the Competent Ecclesiastical Authority".[xlv] Hence in fostering justice Clergy and religious must seek to avoid statements or actions which could be construed as active involvement in party politics. However, this does not mean that the Clergy must be silent on issues of justice which have political overtones. Rather, as official magisterial teaching has directed, the Church's designated Ministers are in general to refrain from proposing concrete solutions for social, economic and political realms, but nevertheless, they are to proclaim issues of justice and denounce instances of injustice. For example, in their preaching, Clerics in Nigeria might condemn asphyxiating policies that are technically and intellectually lauded by the experts but whose prospects of putting a smile on the poor and the downtrodden remains a pipe dream. They can denounce the kidnappings and killings of many defenceless citizens by terrorists from the camp steads in the North-Eastern and North Western and North Central States to the cosmopolitan cities in the South Eastern, South-Southern and South Western States. They can decry the displacement of citizens from the small settlement of farmers in Benue State to the peace loving and hard communities in Kwassam (Kafanchan Diocese). It is the Clergy's responsibility within the context of the mandate that they received from their faculties to hold the Government accountable.

Clergy's involvement in Civic Engagement in Nigeria

The Canons we have examined have expounded that while the Clergy are barred from active participation in politics, they are however fully commissioned alongside the other Faithfuls in the Church as agents for deep social transformation. This mandate they perform primarily through the potent instrument of the pulpit. While the nation bleeds from severe socio-political fractures, hyperinflation, structural insecurity, multidimensional poverty and political brigandage there were several Clergy who recognized that the boundaries given to them in terms of partisan politics is never a mandate for silence. They "preached an undiluted Gospel that pricks consciences, properly informed and empower the laity to take their rightful place within the highly volatile Nigerian socio-political spaces and an unyielding commitment to the common good".[xlvi] The activities of some of these Clergy which are primarily aimed at promoting the common good were described and rightly so as holy activism and advocacy. It does not matter how their civic engagement is described, the important thing to underscore is that whatever they do is aimed at bringing social and political changes through increased public awareness, support for particular cause (e.g. resettling the displaced and building shelters for the homeless), engaging politicians both in person and on the social media. There are so many Clergy across the nation who relying on their mandate to preach are involved in civic engagement. This paper will review the activities of a few of them.

The Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria

The Catholic Bishops of the Nigerian Conference have continued to work within the parameters of the principles of Catholic Social Teachings to defend the civil rights of all Nigerian citizens. The collective and individual letters they published have never departed from the teachings of the Church's *Magisterium* and the Church's Universal Law. They have always sought to find ways to apply the Universal Teachings within the Nigerian context. They have been very frank in addressing the wound of injustice in the various forms it presents itself in the nation. They have been in the forefront of reanimating the conscience of the nation and have never remained silent about criticizing the sinister activities that threatened the corporate existence of the Nigerian

project. The position of the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria in its struggle to ensure a level playground for all was well captured by Jean-Francois Bayart in his analysis of the relationships between the Church and the post-colonial States. He observed that:

> "In spite of the huge symbolic and material investments the State has made in the Church, the State finds it hard to exert its full control on the Church as it does on the politicians and teachers. This is due to the fact that the market of the sacred is particularly evanescent and sensitive to the strategies of the "little" and it is also against the *élite* that frustrate and thwart the established order".[xlvii]

In order to maintain its role as an impartial umpire and to avoid any detraction in its role in promoting an egalitarian society, where justice, equality and protection of the dignity of the human person are sacrosanct, the Conference has renounced every political support.

Furthermore, the Conference has fared well in the maintenance of internal order within its territory. Following the logic of synodality that characterizes the Church in receiving and respecting diversity, the Conference has translated most of the Papal teachings, Curial instructions, etc. into the Nigerian situation.

Before the time the Nigerian Ecclesiastical Hierarchy was officially incorporated on 15 March 1958,[xlviii] the Bishops have been meeting regularly at regional level to confront problems that threatened their missionary activities. One example that could drive home the unison with which the Bishops confront issues that border on their missionary mandate and the welfare of the faithful entrusted to their care would be when the East Nigerian Government declared that from 1957, primary education should become general and obligatory. The new disposition of the Government prescribed that all children between 5 to 6 years of age must be registered into schools chosen by their parents between 7 to 19 May. The disposition also stated that school authorities could not admit pupils in excess of what was established as a cut off number for the current academic year. The excess pupils were to be registered into a special list that was to be forwarded to a committee of nearby schools without putting into consideration the religion that pupils professed. If it happens that the schools were not enough to absorb all the students, it was the Government that reserved the exclusive right to build new non-faith-based schools. In the meantime, the Government would not approve the construction of new Catholic Elementary Schools.[xlix]

On May 27, 1956, the Bishops of Onitsha Ecclesiastical Province published a collective letter that had to do with the schools of the Bishops of Onitsha Province and was read in all the Churches and chapels of the Eastern Episcopal Conference. The Bishops clearly and briefly reaffirmed the principles expounded by the Nigerian Hierarchy in their common pastoral letter that was published in 1953 that declared that:

> Parents have the exclusive obligation and right to send their children to the schools of their choice. Every community has the right to build and to expand existing schools within its territory so that parents could adequately exercise their rights.[l]

The Bishops declared that they were not opposed to the construction of State (Government) schools, as long as that was what the people wanted and as long as they had the right to choose among the many existing schools the one they felt was ideal for their wards. They also asked the Government to let them lay claim to the schools they had constructed in eastern Nigeria with the help of the people. It would be unjust, according to the Bishops, to turn a blind eye to the labour and the money that the construction of these schools had gulped. They declared their willingness to collaborate with the State (Government) in the administration of the schools of the local authority but they decried any form of dictatorship on matters that were related to the education of

most Catholic pupils.[li] The Bishops' stance is prophetic. The Bishops' position is civic engagement. The position they took did not vitiate ecclesial integrity. Their position is exercised within the Church's inherent rights of exercising its *potestas iuridictionis* and *potestas ordinis*. For over sixty years, the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria has through its official communiques remained the official gauge of the collective agony of the Nigerian People.

Bishop Joseph Danlami Bagobri

Most Rev. Joseph Danlami Bagobiri (of blessed memory) was born on November 8, 1957, at Fadan Kagoma, Jama'a Local Government Area. He studied at the St Augustine Major Seminary, Jos, the Franciscan University, Steubenville, Ohio and the Pontifical University of St Thomas Aquinas (Angelicum) Rome. He was ordained a Priest for the Catholic Archdiocese of Kaduna on June 11, 1983, consecrated the first Bishop of the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan on October 21, 1995 and he died on February 27, 2017.

The Bishop who was relatively obscure on the national scene rose to international prominence when, stirred by holy anger over the activities of terrorists within his ecclesiastical jurisdiction, he spoke against the Government whom he accused of being in cahoot with the terrorists that have maimed and killed many citizens within his Diocese. Like a wounded and frustrated prophet, Bishop Bagobiri recounted the unsettling realities kidnapping and banditry in Southern Kaduna thus:

> Between 2014-2016 well over 1.000 people have been killed in more than 4 Local Government Areas in Southern Kaduna, comprising of about 56 villages, several people were injured and some are maimed for life. The numbers of houses destroyed are over 1,500 and not less than twenty churches were destroyed and properties worth ₦5 billion are lost which include houses, shops. Schools, food stores/barns, farmlands and vehicles etc…These attacks were not carried out randomly but are targeted, premeditated and well organized in nature. Research and investigation conducted recently have revealed that the attacks which emanate from the Fulani Herdsmen Terrorist Network, now accounted to the the third deadliest terrorist organization in the world, being preceded only by ISISs and Boko Haram, have followed a certain predictable pattern or modus operandi.[lii]

When it became clear that the attacks were increasing with a ferocious velocity and the sites for mass graves were increasing in geometric progression[liii], the Bishop strongly advocated for self defence among his people. The Bishop had hinged his teaching on self defence on the scriptures and the Catechism of the Catholic Church (cf. CCC 2264-2266) and warned against "absolute pacifism" which he held is dangerous for the corporate survival of any group of people threatened by the maniacal activities of terrorists. Self defence for the Prelate is an act of love towards oneself and in defence of God's gift of life. The crux of Bishop Bagobiri's position on self-defence is that:

> Legitimate defence can be not only a right but a grave duty for one who is responsible for the lives of others. The defence of the common good requires that an unjust aggressor be rendered unable to cause harm. For this reason, those who legitimately hold authority also have the right to use arms to repel aggressors against the civil community entrusted to his responsibility.[liv]

Although the Prelate was an ardent defender of the principle of self-defence in the face of aggression, he was also clear in advocating for restraint and the need to employ the use of reason

before confronting evil. According to him, "direct confrontation or attack in self or communal defence is evil".[lv]

Bishop Julius Yakubu Kundi

Bishop Julius Yakubu Kundi is the second Bishop of the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan. He was appointed Bishop by the Holy See on December 12, 2019, the feast of Our Lady of Guadalupe and canonically installed on February 21, 2020. He succeeded Bishop Joseph Danlami Bagobiri who served for 23 years and was considered a firebrand leader and a vocal defender of the rights of the marginalized people of Southern Kaduna.[lvi]

Bishop Kundi was consecrated a Bishop few weeks shy from the global lockdown due to the Corona Virus outbreak. He therefore had a very quiet start. While the churches, rectories, schools and markets were silent, the merchants of death enemies were spending sleepless night priming their well thought out plans to cast the spell of death on Southern Kaduna through the continued activities of banditry, kidnap for ransom and terrorism.

On March 20, 2022, barely two years into his episcopacy bandits raided Agban Kagoro, Kaura Local Government Area of Kaduna State and torched at least 200 houses and killed 32 people. On March 22, 2022, after the collation of all the relevant data of the incident by the diocesan Justice Development and Peace Commission (JDPC), the Bishop released a Press Statement titled "Enough is Enough". He orated:

> It is quite scandalous that while the pogrom against Christians from Southern Kaduna and the Middle Belt is metamorphosing into genocide, the Government and the International Community's narratives present it as an ethnic clash that can be comfortably tamed by the Nigeria's law enforcement agencies… What is the acceptable number of deaths that qualify for genocide under international law? What is the criterion used by the international community to place value on a life… Our people do not feel the protection of government and with no clear efforts to apprehend these murderers, citizens' trust in government and its capacity to defend them is waning by the day… Government and security agents must promptly do more than the usual moral denunciations and assurances that things are under control.[lvii]

Barely four months after the Agban Kagoro pogrom, two Priests of the Diocese (Frs Johnmark Cheitnum and Cleopas Donatus) were kidnapped and while negotiation for their release was ongoing, it was discovered that Fr Johnmark Cheitnum was killed by his abductors. Fr Johnmark was the first Priest that was gruesomely killed by terrorists in the Diocese of Kafanchan. The broken and inconsolable Bishop, on July 20, 2022 released yet another Press Statement titled: God Finds us in the Midst of our Sorrows". The Prelate lamented:

> The Death of Rev. Fr. John Mark Cheitnum is a tragedy of monumental proportions. The pall of darkness is cast on our diocese, the Church in Nigeria and indeed, the Universal Church. Terrorists whose vain ambition is to intimidate Catholic Priests and terrorize the flock of God entrusted to their care murdered Fr. Mark. Although his death seems to have stirred a heavy storm of despondency on some of our faithful and clerics, we will neither be cowed into losing the faith nor proclaiming Christ crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and foolishness to gentiles (Cf. 1 Corinthians 1:23-25)… I was devastated by the notice of the death of Fr John Mark. However, the news of the escape of Fr. Cleopas Donatus made the

> sense of despair that enveloped me to give way to a profound conviction that God comes to find us in the midst of our sorrows, even when we are trapped by disappointments or betrayed by our own presumptions. God never leaves us where He finds us, unless we insist. I was crushed by the news of the death but I am convinced that his death will prove to our enemies the genuineness and the beauty of our faith… I have said this before but may I reiterate that this is the time for us to drop every divisive element that threatens our collective existence. This is the time to embrace our common humanity. This is the time to form a common force that will fight to a standstill the blood thirsting men of the underworld whose tall dream is to obliterate the indigenous settlements across our nation and further balkanize us along religious lines. It is our unity that will expose the treachery of the enemy within. It is our unity that will expose all those complicit who may pretend to be on the same boat with us but are actually working hard to sink it.

It is a fact that it would be difficult for any Prelate to live in a territory where both the Clergy and the Laity are continuously decimated by the activities of terrorists and bandits and remain neutral to civic engagement.

Bishop Wilfred Anagbe

Father Wilfred Anagbe CMF was appointed the Coadjutor of Makurdi Diocese by Pope Francis on July 8, 2014. He was subsequently ordained Co-adjutor Bishop on October 4, 2014. He succeeded late Bishop Athanasius Usuh as the Local ordinary of the Diocese and was formally installed at a public ceremony at IBB Square, Makurdi on March 28, 2015.

The Diocese of Makurdi which is located in the North Central Nigeria has seen frequent fierce security breeches that caused the lives and property of many citizens. Several families in Benue State have been displaced from their ancestral lands due to the activities of Fulani Herdsmen. The Bishop had directly addressed the Government on March 23, 2026 during his 2026 Cathedraticum celebration. He said:

> The only durable and sustainable solution the IDPs need is to return them back to their ancestral homes, which he said government at all levels has the capacity to do by providing enough security, especially at the border areas, to ensure the safety of the returnees.[lviii]

Bishop Anagbe's advocacy for the good of his people has gone beyond the shores of Nigeria. In his testimony before the U.S. House Foreign Affairs Subcommittee on Africa on March 12, 2025 titled: "Conflict and Persecution in Nigeria: the case for the CPC designation", he recounted that:

> …Makurdi Diocese in Benue State has been the epicentre of the invasion by these herders, who are more like "hired guns" of cattle oligarchs, who manipulate religion to rally the herders to eliminate the Christian population, and cleanse the land in the name of Islam… Concretely, I ask you to re-designate Nigeria as a Country of Particular Concern. This has both a practical and diplomatic meaning, to signal that you are paying attention to what happens to us.[lix]

The event that unfolded after his testimony which led to Nigeria being designated as a Country of Particular Concern (CPC) seemed to be a response to the request he placed before the members of the House.

Fr Williams Kaura Abba

Fr Williams is a Priest of the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan, Kaduna State. He studied Philosophy and Theology at St Thomas Aquinas Major Seminary, Makurdi and St Augustine Major Seminary, Jos, respectively and was ordained to the Catholic Priesthood in 1995. For his postgraduate studies he went to the Pontifical Urban University, Rome, where he specialized in Philosophy.

From 2017, shortly after the demise of the pioneer Bishop of Kafanchan, Fr Williams became very vocal about the plights of the People of Southern Kaduna. Fr Williams uses the traditional pulpit and the pulpit of the social media (virtual pulpit) with tact and prudence to send his messages across the virtual and physical spaces.

He is an advocate of peaceful coexistence among the various ethnic nations that form the beautiful fabric of Kaduna State. In 2021 he developed a reactionary philosophy called "Yakowaism". He holds that "it was established to correct some ills of unhealthy intergroup relations in all its ramifications".[lx] Fr Williams identifies ethnicity as a tool of manipulation that is frequently used by politicians in Nigeria. He therefore recommended the entrenchment of the philosophy of *Yakowaism* in Nigeria's socio- political tapestry as an antidote to the nagging ethnocentrism that is inherently divisive, sectarian, destructive and inimical to the principles of common good.[lxi]

Fr Williams is acutely conscious of the ideological slant and prejudices of the State within which his Diocese is located. Albeit with great inconvenience, he struggles to promote authentic Christian values whether the politico - social conditions are congenial or inimical to those values. He uses his Facebook page as his virtual pulpit to decry the hardships that visit the people of Southern Kaduna. He has been very consistent in his position. He will first denounce the dastard acts and then calls on the Government to do its constitutionally assigned job of protecting life and property.

On July 27, 2026 Fr Williams posted a write up titled: "The Constant Sunrise of Blood and the Endless Massacre in Southern Kaduna". In the write up graphically painted the blood chilling terrorist attack on Naridon village, Ikulu Pari Parish, Kauru LGA, Kaduna State. With the dexterity of a maestro of the pen, he painted the stomach-churning experiences of many communities in Southern Kaduna, starting Naridon village which was the *locus* that inspired the writeup and then extends his macabre narration to other parts of Kaduna State that have frequently come under the attacks of terrorists. He writes:

> These continuous, brutal killings in Southern Kaduna have become an intolerable stain on our collective humanity. We unequivocally denounce this unrelenting bloodshed and fiercely condemn the barbaric attacks by terrorists on our peaceful communities. It is completely unacceptable that human lives are snuffed out daily while the land is systematically reduced to ash and rubble. Kachia, Kajuru, Chikun, and Kauru Local Governments are the worst hit, constantly falling victim to these ruthless terrorist onslaughts. These local government areas have become, sadly so, perpetual killing fields, where citizens wake up each day wondering if they will survive until nightfall. The human cost of this security vacuum extends far beyond immediate violence, as painfully evidenced by the Ariko victims who have now spent agonizing months in captivity. These forgotten souls have languished in the dense forest hideouts of bandits, separated from their loved ones, and subjected to psychological and

> physical torture. Their families are left trapped in a state of perpetual trauma, constantly oscillating between fading hope and absolute despair. The prolonged captivity of the Ariko victims stands as a grim monument to the unchecked audacity of terror groups operating in the state…While we genuinely appreciate Governor Uba Sani's commendable inclusiveness and his deliberate, visible pursuit of peace across Kaduna State, intent must now be backed by overwhelming force…We call upon him to spare no effort, utilize every state resource, and deploy decisive security measures to permanently rid our communities of the terrorists who continue to menace, kill, and dehumanize our people. Our people are entitled to peace and harmony. Enough of the bloodletting and kidnappings.[lxii]

There are many Clergy across the nation that prudently use their virtual and traditional pulpits to hold accountable those that are saddled with the responsibility of guaranteeing the safety of life and property of the citizens (common good). These Clergy have acquired the discipline of maintaining ethical integrity while navigating socio-political realities in the nation.

Conclusion

The Church has, through negotiations with heads of Governments and ambassadors of different nations, offered a platform for humanitarian and mediatory interventions that deescalate global conflagrant situations to manageable ones. In offering these platforms for head of governments to engage in fruitful dialogues for the enhancement of the common good; the Church is always conscious of the fact that she is in the world and not of the world. She is aware of her socio-political responsibility which is guided by the provisions of the Code of Canon Law and the Magisterial teachings. Hence, she does not compromise her standards, nor does she watch with complacency the rots of unjust political and social order. The Church has contributed a lot to the State by getting involved in its socio-political issues and offering a prophetic voice that challenges and transforms the society so that there may be joy and hope for all and sundry.

This paper has sustained the argument that the Church, through the exercise of her *potestas iuridictionis* and *potestas ordinis* has always pursued her primary goal which is to offer hope for life beyond the grave which she does by offering hope for and defending life before the grave through her civic engagement. It has equally maintained that if the Church is to be credible, she must be on the side of the poor and oppressed by making sure that unjust social arrangements do not trample underfoot the rights of the less privileged and keep them always at the margins of the society. It has also reaffirmed from the analysis of the juridical basis for the Church's engagement in advocacy for the promotion of the common good she has to be prophetic in season and out of season and must avoid at all costs the unholy romance that sometimes exists between Church and State.

The findings of this paper from the statistics reviewed from the National Bureau of Statistics and the Catholic Diocese of Kafanchan lend support to the proposition that Nigeria bleeds from severe socio-political fractures, insecurity, multidimensional poverty and political brigandage. The paper recognizes that Clerics do not in any way give up their basic Constitutional rights upon their incardination into a Diocese or an Institute of Consecrated Life. In a very basic term, incardination is a free act, a voluntary one. To argue otherwise would deprive an individual of basic rights because of a religious choice, a choice guaranteed in section 38 of the Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria 1999 (as amended). The application for ordination and incardination is a request to seek membership into clerical order of the Church - a voluntary and perfect society - that has come together for a set of common purposes - *cultus dei* and *salus*

animarum. These purposes are chiefly religious and carried out according to a set of rules approved by the Competent Ecclesiastical Authority. The Clergy who are the agent of the Church are respected to represent her in every sense of the word. Therefore, it is the Clerics responsibility to speak the truth in a society that seems to have phobia for anything that looks like truth. They are to speak the truth that is capable of pricking the conscience of corrupt politicians whose major preoccupation is scheming the best way to loot the national treasury. They are to speak the truth that is aimed at exposing the merchant of violence and insecurity who have found in Nigeria's chaotic administrative and political situations a fertile ground to build stalls for selling their products. In speaking the truth, the clerics must act within the law of the Church which forbids them from transiting in partisanship. It is to be noted that the actions of the Clerics who are ecclesiastical agents are guided by the basic principle of agency which is expressed in the maxim ***qui facit per alium facit per se*** he who acts through another acts himself. This important principle has guided master-servant relationships and has also placed vicarious liability on the master, especially where the servant committed a tort while acting under the instruction of the master. However, the action of an agent who acts outside the law or the instruction of the principal is guided by the principle of ***qui facit per se, facit per se-*** he who acts does the act for himself. This goes to show that a Cleric who decides to ignore the provisions of ecclesiastical laws and gets into active partisan politics as against legitimate civic engagement does so at his own peril and his actions thereof will not vitiate the integrity of the Church. Because the action so carried out is not sanctioned by the Church.

Finally, this paper is making a case for a practical measure to adopt to enhance clerical civic engagements:

Mentoring Young Leaders

The Cleric by the virtue of his calling tend to have a lot of influence on the young. Most people around the mission territory see the cleric as a beacon of light that precedes them to lead them to an extra ordinary experience of joy, love and peace. Since the Cleric has such a grip on the young, he may sample from among the young men and women of his mission territory, those who have flair for politics and leadership and mentor them into becoming studded leaders that can positively transform the art of governance in our nation. Buttressing on the young's disorientation with many things in the nation and their search for meaning and direction in life, Emmanuel Faweh Kazah orates:

> There are so many youths that are losing it because of the lack of meaning in life in Nigeria. Pastoral agents have the responsibility of giving them back hope and dignity so that armed with these; they will launch themselves into mainstream politics, a domain that requires urgent purgation.[lxiii]

It would be of great help if Mission Schools both secondary and tertiary would introduce Catholic social teaching or ecclesiastical civic education that is laced with ethics, oratory and logic. There, the Students will learn that politics is not a dirty game; and where the game has been tainted with corruption, they should learn that it is a Christian responsibility to cleanse. The mission schools should be made into a forum where true patriotism will be introduced. Students should be taught that true patriotism has to do with loving and appreciating Nigeria as it is and it is their responsibility to do everything in their power to bring to birth that which may be lacking presently. Recognizing and cherishing its good and acknowledging and confessing its guilt. The Church's plans to influence the political world must be both short term, by actively exercising our mandate

as the conscience of the nation through her civic engagement long term, by preparing those who would positively influence the future of the nation.

Leading by Example

This paper recommends honesty in the discharge of clerical duties. The work of the Clergy is not strictly confined to the breaking of the word and the dispensation of the sacraments. Clerics are called to demonstrate transparency in the discharge of their duties, bearing faithful witness to the love of Christ and contributing to the permeation of public institutions with the Christian spirit. Mother Teresa of Calcuta once said: "Honesty and transparency make you vulnerable. Be honest and transparent anyway." Clerics should refrain from giving people any reason to begin to suspect them when it comes to the administration of the ecclesiastical goods entrusted to their care. This paper reaffirms that any dishonest transaction can potentially create an environment of fraud, diversion of ecclesiastical goods for personal use, making a mockery of the Church's tradition which insists on accountability and transparency, making the people lose confidence. When a Cleric shows a sign that he is an astute administrator, he can effortlessly influence the members of his community to begin to lead a life that reflects that which he transmits to them. The virtues they learn from him will help them in no great measure to give everyone his or her due and to ensure the entrenchment of peace and development in the polity.

The issues discussed in this paper have received limited scholarly attention. The attention of must scholars have been on the active participation of Clerics in politics without exploring other options in the Code of Canon Law that allows for clerical actions that are capable of sanitizing the socio-political scenes without necessarily breaking ecclesiastical laws. The few models of clerical involvement with civic engagement that this paper provides points to the fact that Clerics can address social ills without necessarily being involved with active party politics. Although the paper has foregrounded an important but neglected issue in canonical sciences to the center, it is also aware of its limitations. It is limited in the sense that the data used are those derived from the National Bureau of Statistics, one Diocese in the North Central (Makurdi) and one Diocese in the North Western Nigeria (Kafanchan). This reality indicates that the scholarship expounded in this paper is nascent and it is open to further investigations.

In the end, the findings of the study illuminate the multidimensional character of civic engagement, encompassing legal compliance, social responsibility, solidarity with marginalised communities, and public accountability and that Clergy can engage in it without compromising ecclesial integrity.

[i] *Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria 1999 (as amended*). Specifically, Chapter II, "Fundamental Objectives and Directive and Principles of State Policy" (see, Sections 14-23).
[ii] Cf. J. Soglia, *Institutionem Juris Publici Ecclesiastici, libri tres, liber I: De Statu Ecclesiae, caput I, § 4 De Potestate Jurisdictionis*, 17-18.
[iii] *Justice in the World*, no. 6, in Joseph Gremillion, ed., *The Gospel of Justice and Peace*, Maryknoll, New York: Orbis, 1976, 514.
[iv] Hao, Zhidong, Shun Hing Chan, Wen Ban Kuo, Yik Fai Tam, Ming Jang, "Catholicism and Its Civic Engagement: Case Studies of the Catholic Church in Hong Kong, Macau, Taipei and Shanghai", in *Review of Religion and Chinese Society*, 1(2014): 48-77.
[v] Putnam, Robert. 2000. *Bowling Alone: The Collapse and Revival of American Community*. New York: Simon & Schuster.
[vi] Adler, Richard P. and Judy Goggin. 3 (2005), "What Do We Mean by 'Civic Engagement'"? in *Journal of Transformative Education*. 236.
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[xxi] Pontificia Commissio Codici Iuris Canonici Recognoscendo, *Schema Canonum Libri II De Populo Dei*, Vatican City: Typis Polyglottis Vaticanis, 1977, 28.
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[xxiii] Coetus Studiorum "De Populo Dei", in Communicationes 12 (1980) 82.
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[xxv] Pontificia Commissio Codici Iuris Canonici Recognoscendo, *Schema Legis Ecclesiae Fundamentalis*, Vatican City: Typis Polyglottis Vaticanis, 1971, 58.
[xxvi] Pontificia Commissio Codici Iuris Canonici Recognoscendo, *Schema Legis Ecclesiae Fundamentalis*,58.
[xxvii] Book II of the 1980 Schema contained no Canon that set forth an obligation of all the Faithful regarding social justice. See: Pontificia Commissio Codici Iuris Canonici Recognoscendo, *Schema Codici Iuris Canonici*, Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1980. No mention of such an obligation was made in the 1981 *Relatio* discussion concerning the rights and obligations of all the Faithful. See: idem, *Relatio*, Vatican City: Typis Polyglottis Vaticanis, 1981, 70-71. The 1982 Schema contained a Canon 222 which was identical to Canon 222 § 1of the CIC 1983, but there was no Canon corresponding to Canon 222 § 2 regarding the obligation to promote social justice. See: idem *Codex Iuris Canonici, Schema Novissimum*, Vatican City: Typis Polyglottis Vaticanis, 1982.

[xxviii] James H. Provost, in *The Code of Canon Law: Text and Commentary,* James A. Coriden et al (eds.), New York/Mahwah, NJ: Paulist Press, 1985, 157.
[xxix] See: Leviticus 25, Amos 2:4-7; 4:1-5; 5:6-7, 10-15, 21-24; 6:1-7, 7-8 and Isaiah 1:11-18; 10:1-11; 58:1-12.
[xxx] See: Luke 4:18-21; 6:20-26; 16-19-31 and Matthew 5:3-10; 25:31-46.
[xxxi] James H. Provost, in *The Code of Canon Law: Text and Commentary, 157.*
[xxxii] Giuseppe Dalla Torre, in Pio Vito Pinto (ed), *Commento al Codice di Diritto Canonico*, Rome, Urban University Press, 1985, 127.
[xxxiii] Giuseppe Dalla Torre, in Pio Vito Pinto (ed), *Commento al Codice di Diritto Canonico*, 127.
[xxxiv] English translations of the CIC 1983 are taken from: Angel Marzoa, Jorge Miras and Rafael Rodriguez-Ocana. *Exegetical Commentary on the Code of Canon Law, Vol. II/1*. 384. This paper's exegesis of Can. 287 § 1 will concentrate on "*pacem…iustitia innixam*- peace …based on justice. Although "harmony" can certainly be viewed as simply a further elucidation of "peace," it may also include the Clergy's obligation to promote unity in the community of believers. See: Concilium Oecomenicum Vaticanum II, Decretum: *Prebyterorum Ordinis*, 7 Decembris 1965 in AAS, LVIII (1966), nn. 6-9, 999-1006. Where the Fathers of the Second Vatican Council discuss the Priest's obligation to foster unity in the local Christian community, as well as relationships among Priests themselves.
[xxxv] As discussed above, however in Can, 222 § 2 mandates that all Christian faithful are to promote social justice.
[xxxvi] Canon 148 § 1 of the 1977 Schema reads: "*Clerici pacem et concordiam inter homines servandam quam maxime semper foveant, in intestinis bellis et ordinis publici pertubationibus nulla ratione partem habeant*- Clerics should always strive, to the greatest extent possible, to foster peace and concord among people, and should in no way take sides in civil wars or disturbances of public order."
[xxxvii] *Coetus Studiorum*, "De Populo Dei", in *Communicationes* 14 (1982) 83.
[xxxviii] See note xxxv above.
[xxxix] *Coetus Studiorum*, "De Populo Dei", in *Communicationes* 14 (1982) 83.
[xl] 1981 *Relatio*, 69.
[xli] John XXIII PP, Litterae Enciclica: *Pacem in Terris*, April 11, 1963, in AAS LV (1963) 260-265.
[xlii] Paul VI PP, Litterae Enciclica: *Populorum Progressio*, March 26, 1967, in AAS 59 (1967) n. 76, 294-295.
[xliii] John Paul II PP, Litterae Enciclica: *Laborem Exercens*, September 14, 1981, in AAS 73 (1981), n. 2, 581.
[xliv] John Paul II PP, Litterae Enciclica: *Laborem Exercens*, n. 16.
[xlv] Latin version of Canon 287§2 in Juan Ignacio Arrieta*, Codice di Diritto Canonico e Leggi Complementari Commentato*, 3rd Edition, Rome, Libreria Colletti, 2010, 246.
[xlvi] Michael Nsikak Umoh. "The Priest, the Pulpit, and Politics: Galvanising a Nation for Responsible Leadership". In THE CATHOLIC VOYAGE: African Journal of Consecrated Life Vol. 23, No. 2, 305.
[xlvii] Cf. J.F. BAYART, *L'Etat en Afrique*, Paris, 1989, 240.
[xlviii] CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF UROMI, *Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria*, in HISTORICAL REVIEW OF THE CATHOLIC BISHOPS' CONFERENCE OF NIGERIA (1958–2026) | Catholic Diocese of Uromi (accessed October 22, 2026).
[xlix] AGENZIA INTERNAZIONALE FIDES*, Nigeria: I Cattolici e il piano governativo per le scuole elementari*, Roma, 13 ottobre 1956, no. 464, 311.
[l] Cf. AGENZIA INTERNAZIONALE FIDES, *Nigeria Orientale: I Vescovi rivendicano il diritto dei genitori di scegliere per i propri figli la scuola che desiderano*, Roma, 16 Giugno 1956, no. 450, 186.
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[lii] Joseph Danlami Bagobiri, *Christians: Seed of Another Humanity*, Lagos, Nilesorphem Ltd., 2017. 13.
[liii] Joseph Danlami Bagobiri, *Christians: Seed of Another Humanity,* 12.
[liv] Joseph Danlami Bagobiri, *Christians: Seed of Another Humanity,* 72-73.
[lv] Joseph Danlami Bagobiri, *Christians: Seed of Another Humanity,* 102.
[lvi] Emmanuel Faweh Kazah, "The Making of a Bishop: An Excursus on Bishop Kundi's Episcopal Appointment, Synodal Approach and Policies", in JORAS, 14 (2025). 140
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[lxi] Cf. Williams Kaura Abba, Inclusion, Fairness, and Good Governance: The Pragmatic Philosophy of Patrick Yakowa,163.
[lxii] Williams Kaura Abba, "The Constant Sunrise of Blood and the Endless Massacre in Southern Kaduna" in https://www.facebook.com/share/1HSAsm7RzJ/?mibextid=wwXIfr. Retrieved October 23, 2026.
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